Naomi in the Living Room

By Christopher Durang

INTRODUCTION

Sometimes one of the most difficult things about being married is not the marriage itself, but the in-laws that come with it. If you have been having a hard time dealing with your mother-in-law, you haven't seen anything yet. Meet Naomi . . . Joanna's mother-in-law. One moment she's nice as pie, the next she's jumping on top of furniture, pulling out her hair, and screaming at the top of her lungs. Poor Johnna finds herself trapped in the absolute craziness of the family she married into during a visit with . . .

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SCENE: *A living room. Enter NAOMI, followed by JOHN and JOHNNA, an attractive young couple. JOHN has a moustache and is dressed in a suit and tie. JOHNNA is wearing a dress with a string of pearls. NAOMI, though, looks odd. NAOMI plants herself somewhere definitive - by the mantelpiece, for instance - and gestures out toward the room.*

NAOMI: And this is the living room. And you've seen the dining room, and the bedroom, and the bathroom.

JOHN: Yes, I know. I used to live here.

NAOMI: The dining room is where we dine. The bedroom is where we go to bed. The bathroom is where we take a bath. The kitchen is where we ... cook. That doesn't sound right. The kitchen is where we ... collect kitsch. Hummel figurines, Statue of Liberty salt and pepper shakers, underpants that say Home of the Whopper, and so on. Kitsch. The kitchen is where we look at kitsch. The laundry room is where we do laundry. And the living room is where Hubert and I do all of our living. Our major living. So that's the living room.

JOHNNA: What do you use the cellar for?

NAOMI: *[suspicious]* What?

JOHNNA: What do you use the cellar for?

NAOMI: We use the cellar to . . . we go to the cellar to . . . replenish our cells. We go to the attic to . . . practice our tics, our facial tics. *[face contorts]* And we go to the carport, to port the car. Whew! Please don't ask me any more questions, I'm afraid I may not have the strength to

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find the answers. *[laughs]* Please, sit down, don't let my manner make you uncomfortable. Sit on one of the sitting devices, we use them for sitting in the living room.

[JOHN and JOHNNA go to sit on the couch]

NAOMI: *[screams]* DON'T SIT THERE, I WANT TO SIT THERE!!! *[JOHN and JOHNNA look frightened. NAOMI charges to the couch]* Shits! Ingrates! It's my house, it's my living room. I didn't ask you, I can ask you to leave. *[JOHN and JOHNNA start to edge out of the room]* No, no, sit down. Please, make yourselves at home, this is the living room, it's where Rupert and I do all our living. *[JOHNNA sits in the chair, and JOHN stands behind her --NAOMI stretches her arms out on the couch]* Wow. Boy oh boy. I need a big couch to sit on because I'M A BIG PERSONALITY!!!! *[laughs]* Tell me, are you two ever going to speak, or do I just have to go on and on by myself, or WHAT!!!!!! *[stares at them intensely; they hesitate but then speak]*

JOHNNA: This is a very comfortable chair. I love it.

NAOMI: Go on.

JOHNNA: Ummmm, this morning I washed my hair, and then I dryed it. And we had coffee in the kitchen. *[pause, doesn't know what to say]* And I love sitting in this chair.

NAOMI: I think I want to sit in it, get up, get up. *[charges over, JOHN and JOHNNA move away, uncomfortable. NAOMI sits and moves around in the chair, luxuriating in it]* Hmmmm, yes. Chair, chair. Chair in the living room. Hmmm, yes. *[shouts at them]* Well, go sit down on the couch, you morons! *[screams off-stage]* Leonard! Oh, Leonard! Come on in here in the living room and have some conversation with us. You don't want me to soak up everything our son says all by myself, do you? *[stands and walks over to the couch. Smiles at JOHNNA]* You probably didn't know John was Herbert's and my son, did you?

JOHNNA: Yes, he told me. I've met you before, you know.

NAOMI: Shut up! *[calls out]* Hubert! Rupert! Leonard! *[to them]* I hope he's not dead. I wouldn't know what room to put him in. We don't have a dead room. *[smiles; screams]* AAAAAAA-AAAAHHH! *[looks at them]* Goodness, my moods switch quickly. Tell me all about yourselves, do you have children? *[listens attentively]*

JOHNNA: We had five children, but they all died in a car accident. The babysitter was taking them

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for a ride, and she was drunk. We were very upset.

NAOMI: Uh huh. Do you like sitting on the couch?

JOHN: Mother, Johnna was telling you something sad.

NAOMI: Was she? I'm sorry, Johnna, tell it to me again.

JOHNNA: We had five children . . .

NAOMI: *[Tries to concentrate, but]* Wait a minute, something's bothering me!!!! *[rushes over to a stuffed Santa pig on the mantel, snatches it up and throws it against the wall in a fury]* This belongs in the kitchen, ***not*** in the living room. The living room is for living, it is not meant for sincerely designed but ludicrously corny artifacts! Kitsch! Do you like Hummel figurines?

JOHN: Very much. Now that the children are dead, Johnna and I have begun to collect Hummel figurines.

NAOMI: Uh, huh, isn't that interesting? Excuse me if I fall asleep. I'm not tired yet, but I just want to apologize in advance in case your boring talk puts me to sleep. I don't want to offend you. *[screams]* AAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHH! I'm so bored I could scream. Did you ever hear that expression? AAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHH!

JOHN: Excuse me, I want to change my clothes. I'm tired of my color scheme. I'll be right back. *[exits]*

JOHNNA: He's constantly talking about his color scheme. It's my cross to bear, I guess. That and the death of the children.

NAOMI: So who are you, anyway?

JOHNNA: I'm Johnna. I'm married to your son. All our children recently were killed.

NAOMI: Stop talking about your children, I heard you the first time. God, some people can't get over their own little personal tragedies, what a great big crashing boor. Lots of people have it worse, girlie! *[calls off-stage]* Hey, John, where did you get this turd of a wife, at the Salvation Army? I'd bring her back! *[laughs maniacally]*

JOHNNA: I think I want to go.

NAOMI: Boy, you can't take criticism, can you? This is the conversation pit. You can't leave the pit until you converse on at least five subjects with me. Starting now, go: *[waits expectantly]*

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JOHNNA: I was reading about *Dan Quayle's [Replace with current VP]* grandmother the other day.

NAOMI: That's one. Go on.

JOHNNA: She said there should be prayer in the schools ...

NAOMI: That's two. *[starts to massage her feet]*

JOHNNA: And that we should have a strong defense ...

NAOMI: That's three.

JOHNNA: And that the Supreme Court should *[was right to]* repeal the Wade vs. Roe ruling that legalized abortions.

NAOMI: That's four.

JOHNNA: And that even in the case of pregnancy from incest, the woman should be forced to carry the child through to term.

NAOMI: That's four-A

JOHNNA: And then she said she hoped the mother would be forced to suffer and slave over a horrible job and take home a tiny teeny paycheck to pay for some hovel somewhere, and live in squalor with the teeny tiny baby, and that then she hoped she'd be sorry she ever had sexual intercourse.

NAOMI: That's still four-A.

JOHNNA: Don't you think she's lacking in Christian charity?

NAOMI: That's five, kind of. Yes, I do. But then so few people are true Christians anymore. I know I'm not. I'm psychotic. Get up off the couch, I want to sit there. *[rushes over, JOHANNA has to vacate fast. NAOMI starts to luxuriate in sitting in the couch, moving sensuously]* Oh, couch, couch, big couch in the living room, you are my manifest destiny. Mmmmm, yes, yes. *[to JOHNNA]* Tell me, can you switch moods like I can? Go ahead, try.

JOHNNA: Very well. *[happy]* I'm so happy, I'm so happy. *[screams]* AAAAAAAH! Do you have chocolates for me? *[desperate]* I'm so sad, I'm so sad. Drop dead! *[laughs hysterically]* Aha-hahahahahahaha! That's a good one!

NAOMI: Very phoney, I didn't believe you for a moment. *[changes subject abruptly]* I don't understand politics, do you?

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JOHNNA: Politics?

NAOMI: Politics, politics! What, are you deaf? Are you stupid? *[Enter JOHN dressed just like JOHNNA - the same dress, pearls, stockings, shoes. He has shaved off his moustache, and he wears a wig with a bow in it like the one she has in her hair. They look very similar]*

NAOMI: You took off your moustache.

JOHN: I just feel so much better this way.

JOHNNA: *[embarrassed]* John and I are in couples therapy because of this. Dr. Cucharacha says his cross-dressing is an intense kind of co-dependence.

NAOMI: If this **Dr. Cucharacha** cross-dresses, I wouldn't see him. That's what **John** here is doing. Too many men in women's clothing, nothing gets done!

JOHNNA: Why do you humiliate me so this way?

JOHN: *[to Johnna]* I want to be just like you. Say something so I can copy you.

JOHNNA: Oh, John. *[looks away with a feminine gesture]*

JOHN: Oh, John. *[imitates her gesture]* That doesn't give me much. Say something else.

JOHNNA: Maybe it's in your genes.

JOHN: Maybe it's in your genes.

NAOMI: This is a disgusting sight. I find this uncomfortable. Makes me want to vomit.

JOHNNA: Maybe we should go.

JOHN: Maybe we should go.

NAOMI: *[upset]* How come you don't dress like me? How come you dress like her?

JOHN: I want to be noticed, but I don't want to be considered insane.

JOHNNA: John, please, just stay quiet and pose if you must, but no more talking.

NAOMI: Insane? Is he referring to someone in this room as insane? *[calls]* Sally! Gretchen! Marsha! Felicity! *[to them]* I'm calling my army in here, and then we'll have some dead bodies.

JOHNNA: Maybe we should go.

JOHN: Maybe we should go. *[keeps imitating JOHNNA's movement]*

JOHNNA: Will you stop that?

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NAOMI: Insane, I'll give you insane! What's the capital of Madagascar? You don't know, do you? Now who's insane? What's the square root of 347? You don't know, do you? Well, get out of here, if you think I'm so crazy. If you want to dress like her and not like me, I don't want you here. *[JOHN begins to walk back and forth around the room, pretending he's on a fashion runway. JOHNNA covers her eyes]* I can have Christmas by myself, I can wait for Santa by myself. I can bob for apples. By myself! Do you get it? You're dead meat with me, both of you. Leave here. I don't need you, and you're dead! *[pause]*

JOHNNA: Well, I guess we should be going.

JOHN: Well, I guess we should be going. *[JOHNNA and JOHN, looking the same and walking the same, leave the house. NAOMI chases them to the door]*

NAOMI: *Nuts to* you and the horse you came in on*! [JOHN and JOHNNA exit. NAOMI comes back into the room and lets out enormous, heartfelt sobs. When they subside she seems to be fairly content]* Well, that was a nice visit.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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